

ART AND CULTURE



RELIGION AND PHILOSOPHY

- RELIGION OF ISLAM
- SUFI MOVEMENT

(PART- II)

MODULE – 14



RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

THE SUFI MOVEMENT

OBJECTIVES

There are two different philosophies in Sufi mystical thought.

WAHADAT AL-WUJUD

- 1 One is the concept of **Wahadat al-Wujud** or the 'Oneness of Existence' which was coined by Ibn Arabi.
- 2 The philosophy emphasises that 'there is no true existence except the **Ultimate Truth (God)**' and that the only truth within the universe is God, and that all things exist within God only.

WAHADAT ASH-SHUHŪD

- 3 The other is the concept of **Wahadat ul-shujud** or the 'Apparentism'.
- 4 This school held that **God and creation are not identical**; rather, the latter is a shadow or reflection of the Divines Name and Attributes.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

THE SUFI MOVEMENT

DIFFERENT SUFI ORDERS IN INDIA

There were many Sufi orders that existed in medieval India, as they were extremely popular with the masses. Some of the major Sufi Shrines were:

1 CHISTHI SILSILAH

2 SUHRAWARDI SILSILAH

3 NAQSHBANDI SILSILAH

4 OTHER SILSILAH

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1

CHISTHI SILSILAH



1

The major Sufi order in Medieval times was the Chisti Silsilah whose geographical spread was from **Rajasthan to Deccan**.

2

Khwaja Muinuddin Chishti in a place called **Herat** in 1192 AD established this Sufi order.

3

The main centre was around **Ajmer** and they worked **amongst the poorest sections** of the society.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

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1

CHISTHI SILSILAH



4 They had many famous Sufis in their atelier like **Sheikh Nizamuddin Auliya**, Sheikh Hamiduddin of Nagaur and many others as exceptional as they are.

5

They wanted to usually stay away from state powers but were linked intrinsically when the **expansion to far flung areas and resettlement** happened as they got of land in Bengal and Multan for their dargahs and Khanqas.

6

The **politics** was so deeply involved with the **religion** that **Sultan Itumish** dedicated his architectural marvel **Qutub Minar** to his saint, **Khwaja Qutubuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki**.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

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1

CHISTHI SILSILAH



The dargah of Nasiruddin Chiragh Dehlavi, in New Delhi

7

The next historical figure through whose life we discover the charting out of the fate of the Sufis in Deccan was **Saiyid Muhammad Husaini Gisu Daraz** (1321 -1422).

8

Other important Chisthti saints included Shaikh Nasiruddin Mahmud who was popularly known as **Nasiruddin Chiragh Dehlavi or the Lamp of Delhi**.

9

In the 15th century, the hold of this silsilah on Delhi started decreasing and they moved to eastern and southern India.

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2

SUHRAWARDI SILSILAH



The Shrine of Bahauddin Zakariya, in Multan, is a major Suhrawardiyya shrine

- 1 The founder of this silsilah was **Sheikh Shihabuddin Suhrawardi** but the responsibility and privilege to get it to India was upon the shoulders of **Sheikh Bahauddin Zakariya** (1182 - 1262).
- 2 They have good relations with the kings and were affluent too.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

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3

OTHER REGIONAL SILSILAH



- 1 The **Firdausia order** was more famous in Bihar and Bengal than other areas.
- 2 The Qadri was prominent in Gujarat and Madhya Pradesh.
- 3 The **Qadri sect** got its moment of glory when the prince **Dara Shikoh** became a student of Mian Mir at Lahore.

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4

NAQSHBANDI SILSILAH



Aurangzeb was a member of the Naqshbandi Sufi order.

- 1 The **Naqshbandi** is a major Sunni spiritual order of Sufism.
- 2 The Naqshbandi order flourished in India during the Mughal period, especially propounded by **Baqi Billah**.
- 3 He was contemporary to **Akbar**'s period.

7 Hence, we would like to conclude that they might not have the power of sharia to back them up legally but **amongst the masses, the Sufis won hearts and allegiance more than the other Islamic sect.**

6 Although the Sufi shrines had important economic socio-political effects on the masses of villagers, yet its main reason was to be a religious institution.

5 They also wrote in **vernacular or local languages** so that more and more people could hear to read their songs and messages.



1 Most of the Sufi saints were given **land grants or inam grant**, which they could pass, to the descendants of the sheikh.

2 These actions **institutionalised the cult of the sheikh** and gave an **economic base to his descendants** to move up the social ladder.

3 The literature of this time is full of instances of a Sufi sheikh predicting **the future kingship** for a civilian, with the prediction **actually serving as a veiled form of royal appointment.**

4 They promoted **religious brotherhood** and equality amongst the masses.

WAHABISM



- 1 Wahabism was the first great modern expression of the awakening of the Arab Islam in the 18th century.
- 2 Its founder was said to be **Muhammad Ibn Abd-al-Wahab**. He preached and propagated the “pure faith” based only on the Holy Quran and criticized the **loosening of moral standards in Islam under foreign influences**.
- 3 It has been variously described as “**ultraconservative**”, “**austere**”, “**fundamentalist**”, or “puritan”; as an Islamic “reform movement” to restore “pure monotheistic worship”.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

WAHABISM



- 4 They advocated **against** **veneration of saints, visiting of their shrines and their worship**. These practices were considered as “**Impurities of Islam**”.

- 5 Today Ibn Abd Al-Wahhab's teachings are the **official, state-sponsored form of Sunni Islam in Saudi Arabia**.

- 6 The **majority of Suni and Shia Muslims** disagree with the **interpretation of Wahabism**.

- 7 Wahhabism has been accused of being “**a source of global terrorism**”, inspiring the ideology of the **Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant (ISIL)** and also justifying their act of killing and global terrorism.

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